



Test Case Prioritization

What to Test When Time is Short

👉 **Author:** Georgia Antoniou

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🚀 **TL;DR**

We rarely have time to run *every* test.

Prioritization ensures we test the **Critical** features first.

The Rule: Run the tests that have the highest Risk (Impact x Probability) first.

🧠 **The Core Concept**

Imagine you have 500 Test Cases and only 4 hours before the release. You can only run 50 tests. Which ones do you pick?

You cannot just pick the first 50 alphabetically. You need a system.

We usually categorize tests into 3 buckets:

P1 - Critical (The "Must Run")

Core functionality. If this breaks, the business stops.

- *Examples:* Login, Checkout, Save Data.

P2 - High (The "Should Run")

Important features. If this breaks, it is bad, but there might be a workaround.

- *Examples:* Filter results, Edit Profile, Export PDF.

P3 - Low (The "Nice to Run")

Cosmetic or rare features.

- *Examples:* Privacy Policy link, Footer color, UI animation.
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The ER Doctor Analogy

Imagine an Emergency Room waiting room is full.

- **Patient A:** Heart Attack (Critical).
- **Patient B:** Broken Arm (High).
- **Patient C:** Paper Cut (Low).

The doctor does not treat them in the order they arrived. They treat the **Heart Attack** first. Even if the person with the paper cut has been waiting longer, they wait.

QA is the Triage Doctor for software.



The MoSCoW Method

A popular technique for prioritization:

- **M - Must Have:** The product cannot go live without passing these tests (e.g., Payment).
- **S - Should Have:** Vital, but not painful to leave for the next patch (e.g., Search history).

- **C - Could Have:** Desirable but low impact (e.g., Dark Mode).
 - **W - Won't Have:** Not testing this time (e.g., Old IE browser support).
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Real World Example: The Banking App

Scenario: We are releasing an update to a Banking App on Friday at 5 PM. We are running late.

The Test Suite:

1. **Transfer Money** (P1)
2. **View Balance** (P1)
3. **Change Profile Picture** (P3)
4. **ATM Locator Map** (P2)
5. **Contact Support Form** (P2)

The Decision:

Time is up.

- We **MUST** execute #1 and #2. If they fail, we cancel the release.
 - We **SHOULD** execute #4.
 - We **SKIP** #3. If the profile picture feature is broken, nobody loses money. We can fix it next week.
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Why This Matters

Recruiters often ask: *"What do you do if you don't have enough time to test?"*

Wrong Answer: "I work overtime" or "I test faster."

Right Answer: "I prioritize. I ensure the Critical path is tested 100%, and I communicate the risk of skipping the Low priority items to the stakeholders."